

Medical Debt Relief

Already have medical debt — maybe in collections? You have rights and real options to reduce or erase it. Below are trusted national starting points. Tick the box once you've contacted each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Medical debt is treated differently from other debt, and you have strong protections. Don't rush to pay a collector before checking whether the bill qualifies for charity care or whether it's even valid.

1 Try to Erase the Debt First

Even debt in collections may still qualify for hospital charity care, which can wipe it out.

☐ Dollar For — Charity Care

Free help applying for hospital financial assistance — it can forgive bills you already owe.

→ dollarfor.org

☐ Undue Medical Debt

A nonprofit that buys and erases medical debt — you can't apply directly, but learn how it works and who it helps.

→ unduemedicaldebt.org

2 Know Your Rights

Federal protections limit what collectors can do and keep most medical debt off your credit report.

☐ CFPB — Medical Debt Rights

Learn your rights, including new rules keeping most medical bills off credit reports. File a complaint if a collector breaks the rules.

→ www.consumerfinance.gov/consumer-tools/medical-debt

☐ Dispute Errors & Validate the Debt

You can demand a collector prove a medical debt is yours and correct. Many medical debts have errors.

→ www.consumerfinance.gov/ask-cfpb/what-is-a-debt-validation-letter-en-2113

3 Get Free Advice

Free, trustworthy counseling and legal help for dealing with medical debt.

☐ Nonprofit Credit Counseling (NFCC)

Free or low-cost counseling to build a plan for medical and other debt.

→ www.nfcc.org

☐ Free Legal Aid

If a collector is suing you or garnishing wages, free legal aid may help.

→ www.lawhelp.org

4 Negotiate What You Owe

Medical debt is often negotiable, especially if you can offer a one-time payment.

☐ Negotiate a Lower Amount

Collectors often accept far less than the full balance. Offer a lump sum and get any agreement in writing before paying.

→ Get any settlement in writing first

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Don't pay a medical collector before checking your rights — many medical debts are wrong, already off your credit report, or eligible for charity care. Never give a collector bank access; pay only with a written agreement.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Always get debt settlements in writing before you pay a cent. And apply for the hospital's charity care even on old debt — getting the original bill forgiven is better than negotiating with a collector.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help with your debt?

This guide covers national starting points. For help with a specific collector, lawsuit, or your state's protections, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll point you to the right help.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
